The Digi-Comp II: counting, adding, multiplying

West bay 3: balls that compute in binary · 26 October 2026

Babbage's Hall, west bay 3. The Digi-Comp II, made by E.S.R. Inc. in 1968, was a computer of marbles: a sloping two-level board of flip-flops and switches that balls rolled down one at a time. Set up with its switches, it counted, cleared, added, subtracted, multiplied and divided binary numbers. Its manual names four registers: the **accumulator** (7 flip-flops), the **memory** (4 bits), the **MQ** (3 flip-flops: multiplier and quotient) and the **distributor** (3 flip-flops), and the switches MULTIPLY, CLEAR, COUNT, COMPLEMENT, OVERFLOW and AUTO/MANUAL.

It is being built here in steps. The first (October 2026) was a counter of three flip-flops; the second (2a) the accumulator, with START, CLEAR and COUNT. This, step 2b, adds **the memory, the MQ, the distributor and MULTIPLY**: it adds and multiplies. Next comes the complement (subtracting and dividing).

What it does

Two levels, as the original: the balls compute on the upper plate, and a ball that is done drops through a hole to the lower level, which carries it under everything else down to the **collector** at the bottom. The upper plate is drawn see-through, so the lower level shows.

The flip-flop is a rocker on a pin: a roof with a cup at each end and a tail onto two stop pegs, with a small steel ball pressed in under the apex. Its centre of mass is a little up the slope from the pin, so it falls over to one side or the other and stays there: a memory of one bit. Apex to the right reads **1**, to the left **0** (printed either side of each apex). A ball rolling straight down meets the roof on its raised side, rolls into that cup, and its weight takes the rocker over; at the end of the swing the cup tips it out. A ball that finds a flip-flop at 0 sets it to 1 and leaves to the right; one that finds it at 1 sets it to 0 and leaves to the left. Nothing else turns the rockers: their shape and weight do it. All thirteen are the same part; where each side leads makes the register.

The accumulator, A is seven of them down a staircase, A1 (the 1s) at the top right to A7 (the 64s):

- A ball that finds a flip-flop at **0** sets it to 1 and leaves to the right, through that flip-flop's **done hole**, to the lower level.
- One that finds it at **1** sets it to 0 and leaves to the left, down to the next flip-flop: the **carry**.

So a ball let into A1 adds one, carrying as far as it must; a ball let into A3 adds four. A carry out of A7 drops through the **overflow** hole.

CLEAR. Under each of A's rockers, on the lower level, is its **foot**: an arm up the slope from the pin, joined to the rocker by a stem through the plate, ending in a wedge. When the rocker reads 1 the wedge leans into the **clear lane** (green), which runs down the lower level past every foot. A ball sent down the clear lane meets each wedge in its way and pushes it aside, which turns that rocker to 0. So one ball clears the whole accumulator. (The other six flip-flops have their feet too, being the same part, but no lane beside them.)

The switches are flaps, set by hand. Each sits at the tip of the divider between two outlets, its free end against one wall of the inlet, closing that outlet: a ball only presses it harder against the wall and leaves by the other. A ball from START meets **MULTIPLY** first. Off, it runs down to **CLEAR**: on, it drops into the clear lane; off, it goes on to **COUNT**: on, it runs into A1 and adds one; off, it drops to the lower level and counts nothing.

The memory, M is four switches, M1 (1s) to M4 (8s), one beside each of A1 to A4. Set to 1, a ball that reaches it runs into that flip-flop of the accumulator (into its funnel, by the funnel's long left wall): M3 at 1 adds four. Set to 0, the ball drops through a hole beside it, and rolls down the lower level to the **return lane** at the board's left edge, and on to the collector.

MULTIPLY on sends the balls to **the distributor, D**: D1 sends them to D2 and D3 by turns, and each of those by turns to its two sides, so four balls go four ways, and the fifth begins again. Set to start (D1 1, D2 1, D3 0), the first ball of every four goes from D2 into **the MQ**, the second to M1, the third to M3, the fourth to M2.

The MQ (multiplier-quotient) is three flip-flops down a staircase like the accumulator's, MQ1 (1s) to MQ3 (4s), but read the other way: **1 with the apex to the left** (it says so beside each). So a ball through it takes one away: the borrow runs on to the left. A ball that leaves the MQ on the right (done) runs on, through the funnels under MQ2 and MQ3, to M4. A borrow out of MQ3, when the MQ was 0, drops through **STOP**.

So with MULTIPLY on, every four balls add the memory to the accumulator, once for each count of the MQ, and when the MQ is used up the next ball drops through STOP and the hand stops turning: the MQ times the memory, added to what was in the accumulator, in 4 x MQ + 1 balls. **ADD** is the same with the MQ at 1 (five balls), as in E.S.R.'s manual.

START is the feeder: a wheel with four notches under the **input** channel of waiting balls. Each quarter turn of its knob carries one ball round from the top and lets it out at the bottom.

Using it

Key	
`Space`	START: a quarter turn of the knob, one ball
`M`, `C`, `N`	MULTIPLY, CLEAR, COUNT on and off (by hand)
`1` to `7`	set that flip-flop of the accumulator over by hand (`1` the 1s ... `7` the 64s), as you set the original's
`H`, `J`, `K`, `L`	the memory's 1s, 2s, 4s, 8s (M1 to M4) on and off
`8`, `9`, `0`	set the MQ's 1s, 2s, 4s over by hand
`D`	set the distributor to start a cycle (D1 1, D2 1, D3 0)
`T`	the tour (it starts with it)
`R`	set it back by hand: the balls to the top, everything to 0, COUNT on, the others off
`Z`	slow motion (1/4 speed) on and off

To multiply: set the accumulator to 0 (or CLEAR it), the memory to one number and the MQ to the other, `D`, MULTIPLY on, and `Space` until a ball drops through STOP. To add, the same with the MQ at 1 and the accumulator holding the first number.

Where to look.

- **The rockers**, against the 0 and 1 printed either side of each apex (the MQ's the other way round), and the 1, 2, 4 ... 64 beside A's: the machine's own reading. Read A bottom (64s) to top (1s) for the

number written the usual way.

- **The switches'** flaps, against the on and off (the memory's 1 and 0) printed at their outlets.
- **The lower level** through the plate: done balls rolling down, a clear ball running down the green lane past the feet, and the memory's dropped balls going to the return lane on the left.
- **The sign** on the table: what the accumulator, the memory and the MQ read, in binary and as numbers, and how many balls have been let in. It is the exhibit's, not part of the machine: the script reads the rockers and switches for it.

Rest the mouse on a rocker, a foot, a flap, the feeder or a wall to see what it is and what it is doing.

The tour (`T`): COUNT from 0, two balls; CLEAR; **ADD** 37 + 11 (the memory 11, the MQ 1, MULTIPLY on: five balls, the last to STOP: 48); CLEAR; **MULTIPLY** 13 x 3 (thirteen balls: 39). After each ball it checks everything the ball should have changed (the accumulator, the MQ, the distributor, STOP) and that the ball reached the collector, and prints `RESULT digicomp2 tour: PASS`. It takes about 180 simulated seconds, and about three and a half minutes of computing here, headless. Twelve balls are not enough for the multiply: when the input runs low the hand takes balls from the collector and puts them back at its top, as you would.

Sliders: `friction` (0.1 to 0.6 checked), `speed`, `steps`.

Running it

Open `digicomp2.lua` in bpp, or run it inside the hall (`HALL_START=digi`). Environment, for testing: `DC_TOUR=0` (no tour), `DC_FRICTION`, `DC_PF` (the pins' friction, as a torque in kg cm^2/s^2: 0.4), `DC_TH` (the board's slope, 15 degrees), `DC_ROLL` (the table tilted across, degrees), `DC_HZ` (steps a second, 2400), `DC_HAND` (the most torque the hand turns the knob with, 50), `DC_PAUSE` (seconds between a reading and the next ball, 1), `DC_LOG=1` (every rocker's lean at each reading), `DC_LOG=2` (also every moving ball four times a second), `DC_LOG=3` (where every ball is at each reading), `DC_CONTACTS=frame` (every contact of the balls, rockers, flaps and wheel at that frame), `DC_REST=0` (never rest), `DC_EXPORT=1` (rewrite `parts/geometry.scad`).

`tests/toggle.lua` is one flip-flop alone, with its foot, its done hole and the clear lane; `tests/switch.lua` is one switch alone; `tests/junction.lua` is the piece of the board where the memory meets the accumulator (A1, A2 and M2: the carry and the memory's balls into the same funnel). Each prints `RESULT` lines; their headers list their settings, and `FINDINGS.md` has what they showed.

Printing and building

`./make-stls.sh` (needs OpenSCAD, and bpp to refresh `geometry.scad`) writes every part into `stl/`, each turned to lie on the bed. Every shape a ball, a rocker or a flap touches comes from `digicomp2-geometry.lua`, the same numbers the simulation uses. The largest pieces are the tiles, 212 x 174 mm (on a 220 mm bed, or turned on a 250 x 210 one).

Part	Print	Size (mm)	Notes
`upper-i-j.stl`	1 each (14)	212 × 167 × 16	the upper plate in tiles, two across and seven down: its 4 mm face with the holes, the walls (12 mm high), the stop pegs, the bosses under the flaps and the wheel, the lettering cut 0.6 mm deep (fill it with paint, or change filament at that layer)
`lower-i-j.stl`	1 each (14)	212 × 174 × 17 (the bottom two 32)	the lower level in tiles: a 2 mm floor with its walls (15 mm), the clear lane, the return lane, the collector's wall (30 mm), the posts that hold the plate up, and the bosses the feet stand on

Part	Print	Size (mm)	Notes
`rocker.stl`	13	44 × 19 × 9	a flip-flop's top. 100% infill
`foot.stl`	13	12 × 24 × 22	its stem and foot: the stem glues up into the rocker's hub, through the plate's square hole. 100% infill
`flap.stl`	7	3 × 19 × 9	a switch's flap
`wheel.stl`	1	39 × 39 × 9	the feeder's wheel
`knob.stl`	1	28 × 28 × 14	glued onto the wheel's hub; its four marks are the quarter turns
`foot-back-1.stl`, `foot-back-2.stl`	2 each	30 × 165 × 30, 30 × 169 × 30	the stand's tall back feet, each in two halves glued end to end (20% infill is plenty)
`foot-front.stl`	2	30 × 21 × 30	its low front feet

Also needed

- **12 steel balls, 1/2 inch (12.7 mm)**, 8.35 g each (and a few spare; with more, a long multiply needs fewer trips to the collector).
- **13 steel balls, 1/4 inch (6.35 mm)**, 1.04 g: the rockers' weights, pressed into the pocket under each apex, flush.
- **3 mm steel dowel pins**: thirteen 32 mm long for the flip-flops (pressed into the lower tiles' bosses, up through foot, stem and rocker), seven 16 mm for the flaps and one 20 mm for the wheel (pressed into the upper plate).
- A **lower board** of 6 mm plywood, 424 x 1216 mm, the lower tiles glued on it edge to edge, and the feet glued under it at its corners.
- Glue; a little dry PTFE or graphite on the pins.

Assembly. Glue the lower tiles onto the plywood, edge to edge, the lanes' walls lining up across the joins. Press the flip-flops' pins into their bosses. Glue the upper tiles together at their edges into one plate (a strip of thin card or tape under each join helps). Put each foot on its pin, wedge up the slope; lay the plate on its posts, the stems coming up through the square holes; press the steel balls into the rockers and glue each rocker onto its stem, roof up the slope. Press the flaps' and wheel's pins into the plate, fit them, and glue the knob on the wheel. Glue the tall feet under the back corners and the low ones under the front, so the board slopes at 15 degrees toward you, and **level it across** (within 2 degrees; see `FINDINGS.md`). Set every flip-flop to 0 (apex left; the MQ's read 0 with the apex right), COUNT on and the other switches off, put the balls in the input channel, and turn the knob a quarter turn at a time.

The knob's first quarter turn after loading fills the wheel: balls come out from the second. (In the simulation, the hand loads the wheel's two notches as it puts the balls back, so the first turn lets one out.)

What is not as built

- **The hand.** The knob is turned by the hand, a quarter turn at a time: in the simulation a motor on the wheel's pin, strong enough not to stall. The hand sets the switches and flip-flops, puts the balls back, by placing them, and watches STOP: it turns no more once a ball has dropped through.
- **AUTO.** E.S.R.'s machine can run by itself: in AUTO, a ball at the bottom rolls under the START lever and lets the next ball go from the top, and the ball through STOP lets none. That is not built yet (`FINDINGS.md` says why); here every ball is let in by a turn of the knob, as in the original's MANUAL.
- **The layout** is this machine's own, not E.S.R.'s: the registers do what the manual says, but where each part sits on the board was worked out here. The distributor is a tree of three flip-flops, and after the MQ and M4 it serves M1, M3, M2 (the manual's order is M2, M3, M1; the sum is the same).

- **The pins** are hinges with a constant friction torque, 0.4 kg cm^2/s^2 (`DC_PF`): PLA on PLA at a boss, worked out in `FINDINGS.md`.
- **The lettering** is drawn on the plate's face, not cut into it; the plate is drawn see-through.

See `FINDINGS.md` for how the numbers were arrived at.